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# James, brother of Jesus

*The brother who did not believe, then became a pillar of the Jerusalem church.*

James grew up in the same house in Nazareth as Jesus, yet John says plainly that Jesus' brothers did not believe in him. After the resurrection Jesus appeared to James, and everything changed. Within a few years James was a leader of the Jerusalem church, one of the "pillars." At the Jerusalem council he gave the ruling that welcomed Gentile believers without making them keep the whole law of Moses. The letter of James, traditionally credited to him, is a plain call to live out what we believe.

## At a glance

|                 |                                                                     |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name            | Greek <i>Iakobos</i> , from the Hebrew name Jacob                   |
| Family          | Brother of Jesus, Joses, Simon and Judas (Mark 6:3)                 |
| Known as        | "James the Lord's brother" (Galatians 1:19); "the Just" (tradition) |
| When            | Leader in Jerusalem c. AD 40s–62                                    |
| Key places      | Nazareth; Jerusalem                                                 |
| Key people      | Jesus; Mary; Peter; Paul; Barnabas                                  |
| Main passages   | Acts 15:13–21; 21:18–25; Galatians 1:19; 2:9–12                     |
| Not the same as | James son of Zebedee or son of Alphaeus                             |

*"Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone."*  
James 2:17, KJV

# The life of James, brother of Jesus

Dates are approximate (AD). Acts and Galatians give the order of events, but not exact years. His death date comes from the Jewish historian Josephus.

c. AD 28–30

Jesus' ministry

## Does not believe

James and his brothers watch Jesus' public work from close by. They urge him to show himself openly, and John adds that "neither did his brethren believe in him." *John 7:3–5; Mark 3:21, 31–35*

c. AD 30

After the resurrection

## Meets the risen Lord

Paul lists James among the witnesses of the resurrection. The risen Jesus appears to him personally. Scripture does not tell us what was said. *1 Corinthians 15:7*

c. AD 30

Before Pentecost

## Prays with the believers

In the upper room in Jerusalem, the brothers of Jesus pray with the apostles, the women and Mary his mother. They are now among his followers. *Acts 1:13–14*

c. AD 36–38

Paul's first visit

## Meets Paul

Three years after his conversion, Paul spends fifteen days with Peter in Jerusalem. The only other leader he sees is "James the Lord's brother." *Galatians 1:18–19*

AD 44

Peter's escape

## A recognized leader

After an angel frees Peter from Herod's prison, Peter tells the believers to report the news "unto James, and to the brethren," then leaves the city. *Acts 12:17*

c. AD 49

The Jerusalem council

## Gives the ruling

When the church debates whether Gentile believers must be circumcised, James speaks last. He quotes Amos and proposes a letter asking only a few things of them. *Acts 15:13–29*

c. AD 57

Paul's last visit

## Welcomes Paul

Paul reports what God has done among the Gentiles. James and the elders glorify God, then advise him on how to answer rumours among Jewish believers. *Acts 21:17–26*

# Key activities

Christians have understood "the Lord's brother" in different ways. Many Protestants read it as a younger son of Mary and Joseph. Eastern Orthodox tradition sees a son of Joseph by an earlier marriage, and Roman Catholic tradition often a close relative or cousin.

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- 1 Doubted, then believed.** He did not believe during Jesus' ministry, but he was among the believers after the resurrection. *John 7:5; Acts 1:14*
  - 2 Saw the risen Christ.** Jesus appeared to him by name. *1 Corinthians 15:7*
  - 3 Led the Jerusalem church.** Peter sent word to him, and Paul called him a pillar. *Acts 12:17; Galatians 2:9*
  - 4 Welcomed Gentiles.** He judged "that we trouble not them, which from among the Gentiles are turned to God." *Acts 15:19*
  - 5 Gave Paul the right hand of fellowship.** With Peter and John he agreed that Paul and Barnabas should go to the Gentiles. *Galatians 2:9*
  - 6 Wrote to scattered believers.** The letter of James opens with "James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ." *James 1:1*
  - 7 Urged a working faith.** He called believers to be "doers of the word, and not hearers only." *James 1:22; 2:14-26*
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## Group notes

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# Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names James.

## Old Testament

|                         |                                                                      |
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| Amos 9:11–12            | Rebuilding David's tabernacle, quoted at the council (Acts 15:16–17) |
| Echo: Genesis 37; 42–45 | Joseph's doubting brothers later bow before him                      |

## New Testament

|                                     |                                                           |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Matthew 13:55; Mark 6:3; John 7:3–5 | Heads the brothers' list; they do not believe             |
| 1 Corinthians 15:7                  | "After that, he was seen of James"                        |
| Acts 12:17; 15:13–21; 21:18         | He leads the Jerusalem church                             |
| Galatians 1:19; 2:9, 12             | Paul meets him and calls him a pillar                     |
| James 1:1; Jude 1                   | His letter (authorship debated); Jude, "brother of James" |
| Tradition                           | Josephus records his death in Jerusalem in AD 62          |

### For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Jesus' brothers say and do in John 7:3–5?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think the risen Jesus appeared to James in person (1 Corinthians 15:7)?
3. *Apply:* James once doubted his own brother. Who in your family is far from faith, and how can you pray for them?
4. *Apply:* Faith without works is dead. What one concrete act this week would put your faith into practice?